Sure enough, a case was filed in a local court against the police for insulting the national flag. The BJP, the RSS and the VHP set up a Rashtra Dhwaj Gaurav Sanrakshan Committee (Committee for Protecting the Honour of the National Flag).[54] What had begun as a local property dispute now became a larger controversy that involved the national flag. The Sanrakshan Committee declared that it did not care who hoisted the flag as long as it was hoisted—implying that refusal to allow flying the tricolour on the disputed spot by anyone was problematic—and the matter turned into a political flashpoint.[55] The state government took a limited, legalistic view, thus playing into the BJP's hands. As an official told reporters at the time, 'The collection of a crowd was what aggravated the Ayodhya problem. We are not apprehending an Ayodhya-type situation but we are convinced that once people are allowed to collect at a place, it could lead to trouble.' The legal view was that, since the Idgah Maidan was disputed property, nobody could hoist a flag in it. 'Even the Anjuman-e-Islam has no right to hoist a flag there,' local officials argued. 'If anyone wants to hoist a flag, they can do so in places specified by the flag code, but not on a disputed land.'[56]

Records from that time show that the state government's decisions on the Idgah Maidan issue were directly monitored not just by the Congress chief minister but also by Prime Minister Narasimha Rao, with Union minister Sikandar Bakht acting as his eyes and ears on the controversy. Between 1992 and 1995, the BJP made five abortive bids to hoist a flag at the Idgah Maidan. It became a rallying point for party leaders across the state and a powerful magnet for the leading lights of the Ayodhya movement. Uma Bharti, for example, was barred from entering the state in 1994. She somehow managed to reach Hubli before she was arrested by the local police. 'I was arrested before I entered the Idgah maidan,' she later recalled. 'I didn't hoist the national flag and had not made any provocative speech … In the entire country this was the only place where hoisting the national flag was banned.'[57] Soon after her arrest, four people were killed and over a hundred injured when the police opened fire to disperse a 5,000-strong crowd that had gathered at the Sawai Gandharva Hall in Hubli's Deshpande Nagar after being turned away from flag-hoisting. The BJP called for a 'black day'